Scientists Listen to Roars to Help Protect Wild Animals

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Animals make lots of sounds. They call to find mates, protect their homes or warn others. Scientists can record these sounds to learn which animals live in a place and how many there are. This science is called **bioacoustics**.

Jonathan Growcott is a **biologist** who studies big meat-eating animals. Finding them in the wild is hard. So he decided to listen for them. His team put 50 sound **recorders** in Nyerere National Park in Tanzania, in Africa.

First he studied leopards. Their deep roars sound like sawing wood. A computer model could tell leopards apart by their roars 93 percent of the time.

Then he studied lions. Using **artificial intelligence**, he found lions make two kinds of roars. He also built a tool he calls "Shazam for lions." It could **identify** a single lion by its roar more than 95 percent of the time.

Word Treasure

bioacoustics -- The science of studying the sounds animals make.
biologist -- A scientist who studies living things.
recorders -- Machines that capture and save sounds.
artificial intelligence -- Computer programs that can learn patterns and make decisions.
identify -- To find out exactly who or what something is.

Background you need

Scientists need to know where wild animals live and how many there are so they can protect them.

Big cats like lions and leopards are hard to see, especially at night.

Sounds can travel far, so recorders can hear animals that people cannot see.

Break it down

WHO: Biologist Jonathan Growcott and his team
WHAT: They used sound recorders and computers to identify leopards and lions by their roars
WHERE: Nyerere National Park in Tanzania, Africa
WHY: Listening helps scientists find and protect animals that are hard to see

Why it matters

Listening to animals can help scientists protect wildlife that kids love, like lions and leopards.

Test what you remember

1. What is bioacoustics?

- (A) Studying weather
- (B) Studying rocks
- (C) Studying animal sounds
- (D) Studying stars

2. How many sound recorders did the team use?

- (A) 15
- (B) 50
- (C) 500
- (D) 5

3. Where is Nyerere National Park?

- (A) Tanzania
- (B) Canada
- (C) Brazil
- (D) Japan

4. What do leopard roars sound like?

- (A) Whistles
- (B) Sawing wood
- (C) Ringing bells
- (D) Rain

5. How many kinds of roars do lions make, according to the study?

- (A) Two
- (B) Ten
- (C) One
- (D) Five

6. What did Growcott call his lion tool?

- (A) Big Cat Camera
- (B) Roar Radio
- (C) Lion Finder
- (D) Shazam for lions

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Jonathan Growcott, biologist: Decided to listen for big cats because finding them in the wild is hard.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):